Group 6 | Task 7 | Shane Snodgrass, Deven Miller, Logan Waller, Matthew Williams, Robert Peterson

Purpose and Audience

This landing page is the main entry point for Plant, a social forum platform where popular posts can grow into their own dedicated forums. Its primary audience is social media users who want community spaces to form naturally around shared interests, from free users to premium subscribers; business accounts reach that same audience through advertising on this page. The layout prioritizes the explore feed so new and returning users reach content within seconds.

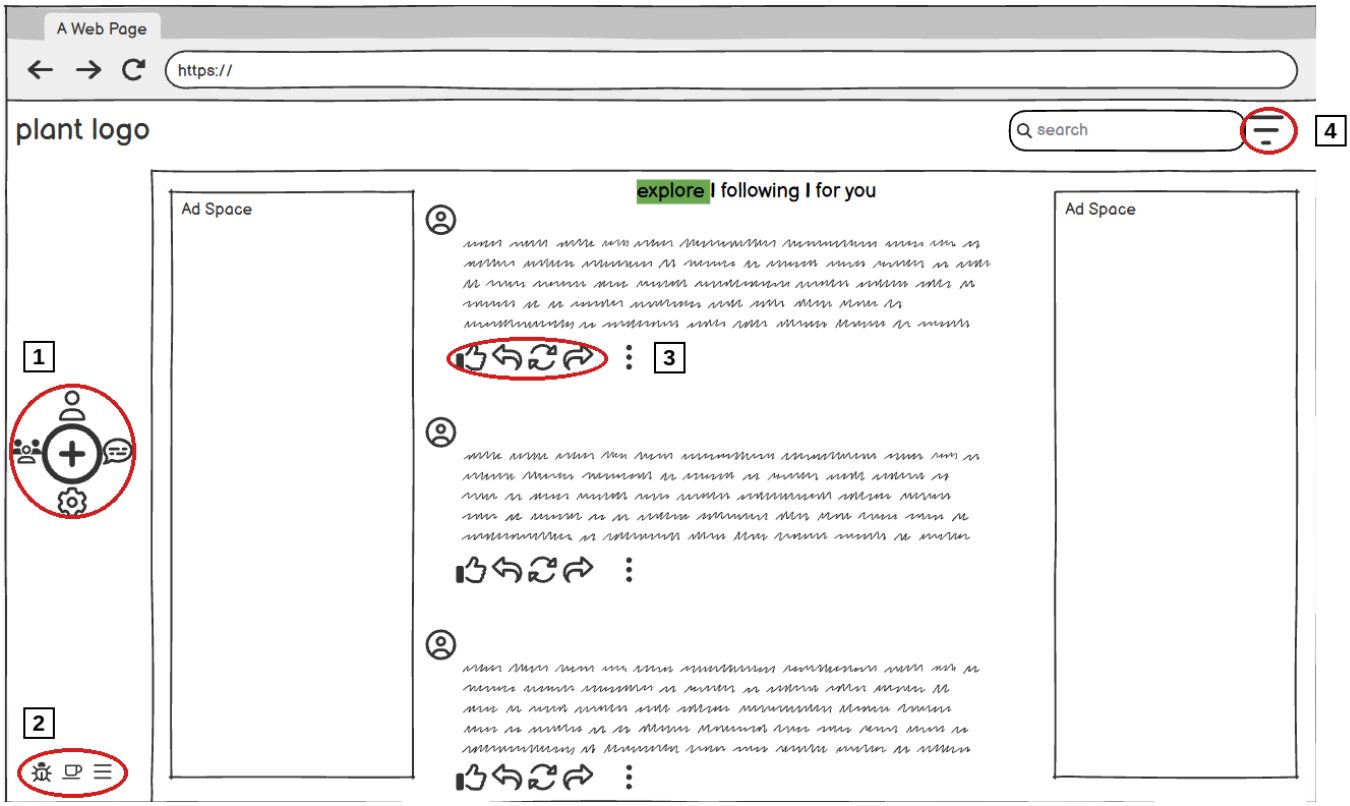


Figure 1. Plant landing page (explore feed) with numbered annotations.

Annotations

1. Main navigation hub. This cluster on the left side holds the app's core actions: posting content, viewing the user's profile, direct messaging, settings, and the forums/communities they have joined. The icons are grouped around a central post button because posting is the app's central action. The hub sits on the left, where users expect primary navigation, and the post button is the most prominent target in the cluster, so the most common action is the easiest to reach. Each icon shows a text label on hover or focus so its function is clear to new users.

2. Support and extras menu. This small group in the bottom-left corner holds secondary functions: reporting bugs to the developers, donating to support development ("buy us a coffee"), and a link to a page with the FAQ and post advertising options. These actions matter but are not part of everyday browsing, so they are kept out of the way of the main hub while staying reachable. Each icon is labeled on hover so the three purposes stay distinct.

3. Post interaction bar. This row sits beneath every post and lets users react, reply, repost, and share. Keeping the actions directly under the content they apply to follows the principle of proximity, and the repeated placement on every post makes the pattern easy to learn. Less frequent actions, such as reporting a post, sit behind the three-dot overflow menu to keep the bar uncluttered.

4. Search filter. Selecting this filter icon beside the search bar opens a small panel of keywords, topics, and trending posts that users can choose from to narrow their search. Each selection includes its own search field for further refinement. The filter icon is a familiar convention for narrowing results, and placing it next to the search bar keeps all search tools in one area of the page.

Design Explanation

The landing page is built around the explore feed, which shows posts similar to the user's interests along with trending content. Tabs above the feed (Explore, Following, For You) let users switch between discovery and content from people they follow, and the active tab is highlighted so users always know where they are.

The layout follows the canonical webpage form presented in L08 (slides 10–14): the logo at the top left, search at the top right, primary navigation on the left, and content in the center. Following these conventions lets users apply what they already know from other social platforms, which shortens the learning curve and supports our goal of an interface intuitive enough for new users.

We made one deliberate departure from convention: advertisements appear on both sides of the feed instead of in a single sidebar. Ads are hosted on the explore page, so this is where they need to be visible to generate revenue, and splitting them across both sides leaves the center column free so they compete less with the posts. We recognize the tradeoff, since side ads take up horizontal space and can still distract. On mobile, the ad columns are hidden so the feed keeps priority, and advertisements instead appear as standalone posts within the feed, so ad visibility does not depend on the side columns.

Throughout the design, controls are grouped by function and frequency of use. Everyday actions sit close at hand, while occasional ones are placed in secondary locations. Icon labels appear on hover so the interface stays uncluttered without becoming hard to learn.